

Helpful Technology for Phone, TV, and Daily Life

Category: Use Your Tools Well

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, adults struggling with phone/TV/alerts/public spaces, family members

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Why hearing technology is more than hearing aids

Hearing aids can be very helpful, but they are not the only tools available for adults with hearing loss. Some listening situations are difficult because of distance, background noise, poor room acoustics, unclear speech, or limited visual cues. In these situations, additional technology may help.

Assistive listening technology can support communication in specific daily situations, such as phone calls, television, meetings, appointments, restaurants, group conversations, religious services, alarms, and emergency alerts.

The goal is not to use every device. The goal is to choose the tools that match your real-life needs.

What is assistive listening technology?

Assistive listening technology includes devices and tools that help people with hearing loss communicate, hear speech more clearly, receive alerts, or access spoken information in another way.

Some tools work with hearing aids. Some work without hearing aids. Some are built into smartphones, televisions, computers, or public spaces.

Examples include:

- Remote microphones
- TV streamers
- Bluetooth hearing-aid streaming
- Captioned phones
- Smartphone captioning tools
- Video-call captions
- Alerting devices
- Vibrating alarms
- Doorbell alerts
- Smoke alarm alerts

- Public assistive listening systems
- Telecoil or hearing loop systems
- FM or digital wireless systems
- Speech-to-text apps

Assistive technology is not a sign that hearing aids failed. It is part of a complete communication plan.

Why hearing aids may not be enough in every situation

Hearing aids improve access to sound, but they cannot remove every listening barrier. Background noise, distance, room echo, and multiple speakers can still make communication difficult.

For example:

- A hearing aid may help you hear your spouse at home but not clearly hear a speaker across a large room.
- A hearing aid may help with conversation in quiet but not fully solve restaurant noise.
- A hearing aid may help with television volume but not always make dialogue clear.
- A hearing aid may help with phone calls but may still need Bluetooth, captions, or streaming support.

Assistive technology can sometimes improve the signal by bringing the speaker's voice or media sound closer to your ears or hearing devices.

Remote microphones

A remote microphone is a small microphone placed near the person speaking. The microphone sends the speaker's voice directly to your hearing aids, cochlear implant processor, receiver, or other listening device.

Remote microphones can be helpful when:

- The speaker is far away
- There is background noise
- You are in a meeting
- You are in a restaurant
- You are in a car
- You are attending a lecture
- You are at a religious or community event
- You are trying to hear one main speaker

A remote microphone may be clipped to the speaker's clothing, placed on a table, or passed between speakers depending on the device.

Remote microphones do not make every situation perfect, but they can improve access to speech when distance and noise are the main problems.

When to ask about a remote microphone

Ask your audiologist about a remote microphone if you often struggle in:

- Restaurants
- Family gatherings
- Work meetings
- Medical appointments
- Religious services
- Classes or lectures
- Car conversations
- Group conversations
- Noisy places where one person is the main speaker

You can ask:

“Would a remote microphone help in the situations where my hearing aids are not enough?”

You should also ask whether the remote microphone is compatible with your hearing aids, cochlear implant, smartphone, or receiver.

Television listening tools

Many adults with hearing loss have difficulty understanding television dialogue. Turning up the volume may help the person with hearing loss, but it may be uncomfortable for others in the home. Also, louder does not always mean clearer.

Television listening options may include:

- TV streamers that send sound directly to hearing aids
- Wireless TV headphones
- Bluetooth streaming, depending on the television and hearing aids
- Closed captions
- Sound bars or speakers designed to improve dialogue clarity
- Personal amplifiers
- Adjusting television audio settings, such as dialogue enhancement when available

Captions can be especially helpful because they give visual access to spoken information. Many people benefit from using both sound and captions together.

Helpful question for your audiologist:

“What is the best TV listening option for my hearing aids and home setup?”

Phone call options

Phone calls can be difficult because you cannot see the speaker's face. Sound quality may also vary depending on the phone, connection, speaker, background noise, and hearing technology.

Helpful phone options may include:

- Bluetooth streaming to hearing aids
- Speakerphone in a quiet room
- Captioned telephone services
- Smartphone live caption features
- Video calls with captions
- Text messaging for important details
- Hearing-aid phone programs
- Telecoil-compatible phones when appropriate
- Adjusting phone volume or audio settings

For important information, such as appointments, addresses, instructions, or medication details, written confirmation can reduce mistakes.

Helpful phrase:

“Can you text or email that information to me so I have it correct?”

Video calls and online meetings

Video calls can be easier than regular phone calls because you may be able to see the speaker's face. However, they can still be difficult if the audio is poor, speakers talk over one another, or captions are not available.

Helpful video-call strategies include:

- Turn on captions when available
- Use headphones or hearing-aid streaming
- Ask speakers to use a microphone
- Ask participants to speak one at a time
- Keep cameras on when possible
- Ask for an agenda before the meeting
- Request written follow-up after important meetings
- Reduce background noise in your own room
- Use chat for names, numbers, links, or instructions

Helpful phrase:

“Could we turn on captions and have one person speak at a time?”

Captioning tools

Captions provide written access to spoken language. They can help with television, videos, phone calls, video calls, meetings, public presentations, and some live conversations.

Captioning options may include:

- Television captions
- Movie captions
- Video-call captions
- Smartphone live captions
- Captioned telephone services
- Speech-to-text apps
- Meeting transcription tools
- Public event captioning when available

Captions may not be perfect. Automatic captions can make mistakes, especially with background noise, accents, technical words, names, or fast speech. Still, captions can provide helpful support and reduce listening effort.

Captions are most useful when they are used along with good communication strategies, clear sound, and visual access to the speaker.

Alerting devices for safety and independence

Hearing loss can make some warning sounds or household alerts harder to detect. Alerting devices can help by using flashing lights, vibration, louder sound, or smartphone alerts.

Alerting devices may connect to:

- Doorbells
- Telephones
- Alarm clocks
- Smoke alarms
- Carbon monoxide alarms
- Baby monitors
- Timers
- Security systems
- Weather alerts
- Emergency notifications

Some devices send alerts to a phone, smartwatch, vibrating pad, lamp, or visual signal.

These tools may be especially helpful for people who do not reliably hear alarms, doorbells, or emergency sounds.

Important note: safety devices should be selected carefully. Smoke alarms and carbon monoxide alarms should meet current safety standards and be installed according to manufacturer and local safety guidance.

Public assistive listening systems

Some public spaces have assistive listening systems that send sound from a microphone or sound system to a listener's hearing device or receiver.

These systems may be available in:

- Theaters
- Places of worship
- Auditoriums
- Classrooms
- Lecture halls
- Meeting rooms
- Museums
- Airports
- Public service counters
- Community centers

Types of public assistive listening systems may include:

- Hearing loop systems
- FM systems
- Infrared systems
- Digital wireless systems

Some systems work with a telecoil inside a hearing aid or cochlear implant processor. Others require a separate receiver or headset.

If you are not sure whether your hearing aids have a telecoil, ask your audiologist.

Helpful phrase:

“Do you have an assistive listening system available?”

Telecoil and hearing loops

A telecoil, sometimes called a T-coil, is a small part inside some hearing aids and cochlear implant processors. It can connect with hearing loop systems in some public places.

When a hearing loop is available and your telecoil is activated, sound from the room's microphone system may be sent directly to your hearing device. This can improve access to speech in certain public settings.

Not all hearing aids have telecoils, and not all public places have hearing loops. If this is important for your daily life, ask your audiologist whether a telecoil is available and appropriate for your hearing devices.

Questions to ask:

- Do my hearing aids have a telecoil?
- Is the telecoil activated?
- How do I switch to the telecoil program?
- Where might I use it?
- Are there hearing loops in places I visit often?

Smartphone accessibility tools

Smartphones can provide many helpful accessibility features. Depending on the phone and hearing devices, options may include:

- Hearing-aid streaming
- Live captions
- Sound recognition alerts
- Text-to-speech or speech-to-text tools
- Visual or vibration alerts
- Amplified ringtone or vibration settings
- Bluetooth connections
- Hearing device control apps
- Video calls
- Text messaging
- Emergency alerts

Smartphone tools vary by brand, model, software version, and hearing device compatibility. Ask your audiologist to help you identify which features match your hearing aids and communication needs.

Choosing the right tool for the problem

The best tool depends on the listening problem.

If the problem is **television**, consider:

- Captions
- TV streamer

- Wireless headphones
- Dialogue-enhancing settings
- Hearing-aid streaming

If the problem is **phone calls**, consider:

- Bluetooth streaming
- Captioned phone service
- Smartphone captions
- Video calls
- Written follow-up

If the problem is **restaurants or groups**, consider:

- Remote microphone
- Hearing-aid noise program
- Seating strategies
- Rephrasing and communication strategies

If the problem is **meetings**, consider:

- Captions
- Remote microphone
- Written agenda
- Meeting notes
- Assistive listening system

If the problem is **safety alerts**, consider:

- Visual alerts
- Vibrating alerts
- Smartphone alerts
- Smoke and carbon monoxide alerting systems

If the problem is **public spaces**, consider:

- Telecoil
- Hearing loops
- FM or infrared receivers
- Captions when available

Questions to ask your audiologist

Your audiologist can help you decide which technology fits your hearing loss, hearing devices, lifestyle, and budget.

Ask:

- What technology works with my hearing aids?
- Do my hearing aids connect to my phone?
- Do my hearing aids connect to a TV streamer?
- Would a remote microphone help me?
- Do I have a telecoil?
- How do I use public assistive listening systems?
- What captioning tools do you recommend?
- What can help me hear phone calls better?
- What can help me hear television better?
- What alerting devices should I consider?
- Are there lower-cost options?
- Can you show me how to use the device before I buy it?
- Can I try it in the clinic?

Technology is most helpful when it is matched to a real problem and taught clearly.

Before buying hearing technology

Before buying a device, consider:

- What problem am I trying to solve?
- Does it work with my hearing aids or phone?
- Is it easy for me to use?
- Does it require charging?
- Does it need Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, or an app?
- Can I return it if it does not help?
- Is there customer support?
- Will my audiologist help me set it up?
- Does it fit my budget?
- Is there a simpler option?

A more expensive tool is not always the best tool. The best tool is the one that solves your specific problem and is easy enough to use consistently.

Key Takeaway

Hearing aids are important, but they are not the only tools available. Assistive listening technology can help with phone calls, television, meetings, restaurants, alerts, public spaces, and daily communication. The best choice depends on your hearing needs, lifestyle, hearing devices, and goals. Ask your audiologist which tools are most appropriate for the situations where you struggle most.

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